

Communication

Character **First****GOALS MONTH 4**

- You can apply the I-Message model in a real situation from your sports life
- You give constructive feedback to a teammate without triggering blame or defensiveness
- You plan and have at least one difficult conversation you have been postponing

How you speak determines how you work together. You learn the difference between reacting and truly communicating, and how to give feedback without damaging relationships.

EXERCISE 1 — I-MESSAGE**1 The I-Message**

The model: "I see... I feel... I need... I ask you to..." Write a situation from your sports life using this model.

I SEE...

I FEEL...

I NEED...

I ASK YOU TO...

EXERCISE 2 — DIFFICULT CONVERSATION**2 The Conversation I Keep Postponing**

Write a conversation you have wanted to have for a long time but keep postponing. With a coach, teammate, or parent.

Who is this conversation with?

Why do I keep postponing it?

Write the first sentence with which you open the conversation (use the I-Message):

When will I plan this conversation? (date + place)

EXERCISE 3 — FEEDBACK ROUND REFLECTION**3 After the Feedback Round**

What was the best feedback you received? What will you concretely do with it?

"Communication is the most important skill any leader can possess."

Doc Rivers — NBA Head Coach

Communication

Character **First**

SCIENTIFIC FOUNDATION — EVIDENCE PYRAMID

Systematic Review Tod et al. (2011) — communication training in sports teams improves cohesion and performance.

RCT Holt et al. (2020) — 8 weeks NVC: significantly higher social cohesion and fewer conflicts. *Psychology of Sport & Exercise*.

Observational Turnnidge & Côté (2018) — positive communication correlates with enjoyment and motivation in young athletes.

GUIDANCE FEEDBACK TRIO ROUND

- 1 Groups of three. Role A: giver, Role B: receiver, Role C: observer (tone and word choice only, not content).
- 2 After each round (3 min): observer gives 30 sec: "You said... That sounded like..." No judgment. Then switch roles.
- 3 Close: "What was hardest about giving? About receiving?" Answers lead group conversation.

COACH TIPS FOR THIS THEME

Tip 1: Use the I-Message yourself. Stop "You did that wrong." Start "I see..."

Tip 2: Have players plan a date for the difficult conversation. Accountability is essential.

Tip 3: U14-U16: empathy is developing. One conscious I-message per month is already a success.

⚠ Feedback round can get intense with group tension. Scan dynamics first. Start with strengths in a tense atmosphere.

TIMING

- ☐ I-Message explanation: 8 minutes
- ☐ Individual practice: 8 minutes
- ☐ Feedback Trio Round: 15 minutes
- ☐ Debrief: 7 minutes
- ☐ Planning difficult conversation: 2 minutes